

Sheesh Mahal (Palace of Mirrors)

شیش محل

1. Basic Facts

- Built by: Emperor Shah Jahan; architect commonly credited as Asif Khan (some popular sources instead credit Ustad Ahmad Lahori, the architect associated with the Taj Mahal - sources disagree)
- Built in: 1631-1632 CE
- Cost: Not documented in available sources
- Built for: A private residential and council chamber for the emperor and his innermost circle; later a favoured private residence of Maharaja Ranjit Singh

2. Construction Details

- Materials: Marble, decorated plaster, and thousands of small convex glass mirror pieces
- Techniques: Up to five distinct decorative crafts are combined - pietra dura stone inlay, fresco painting, stone carving in relief, marble work, stone and wooden fretwork, glass mosaic mirror-work (aina-kari), and gilded stucco tracery (munabbat-kari)
- Craftsmen involved: Not individually documented, though popular tradition associates the mirror-work tradition with artisans skilled in Persian and Central Asian glass techniques
- Time taken: Roughly one to two years for the initial construction (1631-32), though later redecoration layers were added over subsequent centuries

3. Historical Background

- Scholars still debate how much of the visible mirror-work is original 17th-century Mughal work versus later Sikh-period redecoration layered over earlier Mughal frescoes.
- Under British administration, sovereignty over Punjab was formally transferred inside the Sheesh Mahal, according to the 1893-94 Gazetteer of the Lahore District.
- Structurally stiffened in 2002-2005 (an intervention later found to have caused some ceiling deformation); the building was a factor in Lahore Fort's placement on the UNESCO List of World Heritage in Danger around 2000, and has undergone extensive restoration since 2012, with further AFD-funded conservation work on its mirror-decorated ceiling, stucco tracery and gilding reported through 2025-2026.

4. Interesting Facts / Trivia

- A shallow basin with four fountains sits in the courtyard directly in front of the Sheesh Mahal, fed by channels from adjoining buildings - designed so the sound and reflected light of moving water would complement the mirrored interior.
- Even a single small candle or oil lamp, multiplied by thousands of hand-set mirror facets, could once fill the entire hall with light - one of the most-cited (and functionally true) facts about the building's design purpose.

- A number of very specific-sounding statistics about the Sheesh Mahal circulating online (for example precise percentages of mirror loss attributed to a named study) come from low-authority blog sources rather than AKTC, WCLA or UNESCO publications and should not be treated as verified fact.

5. Scenario / Narrative Moment

Picture a single oil lamp being lit at dusk inside the Sheesh Mahal in the 1630s - and the whole ceiling answering back at once, a thousand tiny mirrored fragments scattering that one small flame into what must have looked, to a first-time visitor, like a roof made of stars. Three hundred years later, Maharaja Ranjit Singh chose this same shimmering room, of all the rooms in the fort, as the one he wanted for himself.

AI Heritage Revive — Lahore Fort landmark reference. Compiled from encyclopedic research report; figures marked "Not documented" are intentionally left blank rather than estimated.